

2008 Berlin Interpretation of Roguelikes



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death. The goal is to make it through a series of these randomly generated dungeons and make choices between the available loot to maximise strength and make it to the end. But if the player dies, then that marks the end of that run, and you need to start again from the very beginning with nothing in your pocket. This makes sure that each run in the game is a new experience, which constitutes the core of most roguelike games.

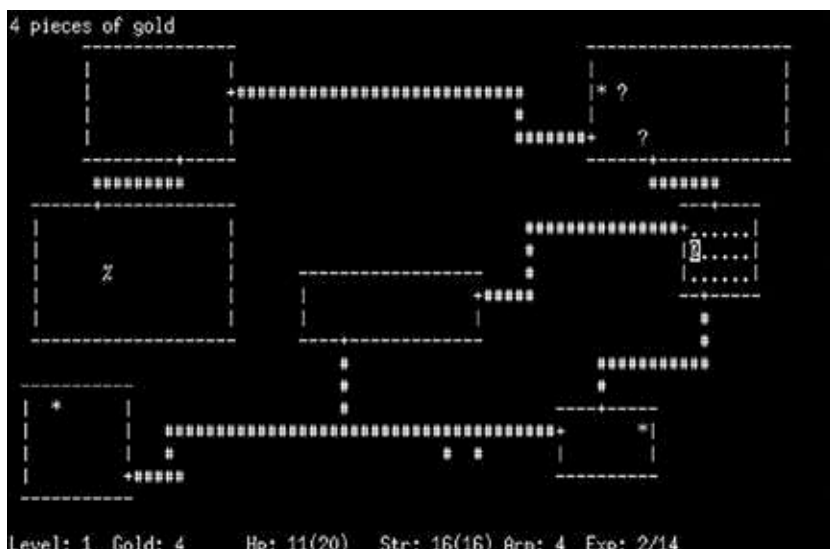
Even with a similar design foundation, roguelike games released in the past decade have demonstrated a unique character and style. They have proven to be highly adaptable to drastically new ideas. This is characteristically different from other genres of games that can only differentiate themselves in terms of their narrative,

aesthetics and graphics. The variation found in mechanics can be wildly different among roguelike games compared to other genres. A roguelike game can encompass a dungeon crawler, a turn-based battler, real-time combat, card games, tactics based gameplay, platformers, and so much more. Tweaking the basic formula can vividly create different experiences in a roguelike game, especially when it creates a synergy with other game elements. If we take away turn-based combat and switch it up with real-time combat, it can create higher stakes for the player with less time to think, making the gameplay more exciting and rewarding them for improvisation and quick action. It also coerces them to understand and master the underlying mechan-

ics of the game to perform better on subsequent runs.

A core mechanic of roguelikes is perma-death, which means you lose all your progress (including any power-ups) if you die and will have to start again from the first stage. While this raises the game's stakes, making the gameplay more thrilling, it can also deter a lot of casual gamers for numerous reasons. Starting from scratch can be frustrating for many of them, and investing hours upon hours in a game with no tangible progress can be disheartening. Studios have tried time and time again to account for this lack of tangible progress and circumvent it using creative solutions while also not impacting the game's structure. Binding of Isaac and Enter the Gungeon let the player unlock fun stuff with no impact on the difficulty of the gameplay. Nuclear Throne allows them to unlock new characters while Downwell unlocks cosmetic upgrades. Hades goes in a different direction altogether, where it unlocks new lore before every run, encouraging the player to keep on to know more about all the characters in the House of Hades.

Changing the roguelike formula to provide permanent upgrades through different runs warranted a significant change to have a genre of its own, called roguelites. Where roguelike games depend on the player to master the game, roguelite games assist them with upgrades that they acquire through different runs. It creates an entirely different difficulty dynamic in contrast to roguelikes and traditional games. Roguelikes only scale up in difficulty from one level to the other and do not change their difficulty scale over time, and classic games scale up with player skill and progress in the narrative. But roguelite games follow a completely flipped approach where the game difficulty becomes easier as the user becomes more proficient at the game. This can be a problem sometimes, as the game needs to keep on challenging the player while keeping the difficulty level digestible at the same time. But,



Rogue: Godfather of Roguelikes